OBC Bahujan Party. "We have been electing Maratha leaders for years, and, today, they want to snatch the benefits meant for our children." Claiming they won't target any specific party but only Maratha candidates wherever they are fielded, Shendge is hopeful that "if there is more than one Maratha nominee in the fray [for any seat], our candidate can sail through if the OBC vote remains intact".

But that's a big "if". The lack of homogeneity among the OBCs has hindered the creation of any pan-Maharashtra identity and solidarity. A veteran OBC leader, who wishes to remain anonymous, points out that while the OBCs had created a rainbow coalition cutting across party lines to protect their reservations, it's wrong to presume that this will translate into any political gain. A large section of the OBCs, believe political observers, are likely to vote along party lines, especially in favour of the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) or the BJP.

Shendge, who belongs to the Dhangar (shepherd) community, is planning to fight from Sangli and has got the backing of the Prakash Ambedkar-led Vanchit Bahujan Aghadi. Lingayat leader Avinash Bhosikar will contest from Nanded, and T.P. Munde, a Vanjari, from Beed. Other seats being eyed are Baramati, Parbhani, Hingoli, Jalna, Ahmednagar, Dharashiv (Osmanabad), Shirdi, Hatkanangale, Yavatmal-Washim, Wardha, Thane, Shirur, Amravati and Mumbai North East.

"There was caste-based polarisation during the Maratha quota stir," says political analyst Abhay Deshpande, "and this may affect the voting patterns in some respect. But the question is, whose prospects will it damage? Most OBC votes go to the BJP, and hence this may hurt the party." Chandrakant Bawkar, who heads the OBC Janmorcha and is the vice-president of the new party, is hoping that the counter-polarisation will help them consolidate the OBC vote. While the Lok Sabha election will give them an opportunity to test their strength, the real target for the party is the state assembly election later this year. ■

MARATHAS VS OBCs

- **The dominance of the Marathas, a group of castes comprising landowners, those of a martial past as well as peasants, is based on the notion that they form nearly a third of the population**
- **However, the OBC Kunbis, who are dominant in the Konkan and Vidarbha regions, are part of these estimated numbers, an extrapolation of the 1931 caste census**
- **More realistic estimates suggest that the Marathas account for just around 12-16 per cent of the population, and the OBCs together come to around 52 per cent**
- **But a lack of homogeneity among the OBCs, who are scattered across the state, has hindered the creation of their pan-Maharashtra identity and solidarity**
- **The Maratha agitation, which saw the OBC quota being effectively extended to Marathas who can prove their lineage from Kunbis besides a separate 10 per cent quota for the community in jobs and education, has led to counter-mobilisation by the OBCs**

On March 27, Odisha chief minister and Biju Janata Dal (BJD) president Naveen Patnaik announced the first list of the party's candidates for the simultaneous four-phase polls, starting May 13. For the state's 147 assembly constituencies, 72 names were made public, confirming that Patnaik will re-contest from Hinjili for a sixth term. And for the 21 Lok Sabha seats, 15 names were put out. The party inducted 13 new faces for the state poll and renominated four of its parliamentary candidates. Among the new names in the Lok Sabha list is general secretary (organisation) Pranab Prakash Das who will take on Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan, currently a Rajya Sabha member, in Sambalpur.

These were not easy calls and were taken after serious deliberations, sources say. Patnaik has been actively engaging with his party's public representatives to gauge the mood of the electorate. The need for such meetings became evident to the 77-year-old leader following the breakdown of alliance talks with the BJP, which endured a strenuous tug-of-war lasting over two weeks.

The efforts to forge a front—dismissed by critics as an untenable idea—were initiated after Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Patnaik praised each other in public. Modi even called Patnaik his *mitr* or friend as the latter extended his party's support to the BJP to re-elect Union minister Ashwini Vaishnaw to the Rajya Sabha from the state. However, on March 22, the BJP's state chief Manmohan Samal announced on social networking site X his party's decision to contest all the 21 seats in the Lok Sabha and 147 in the assembly "under the farsighted leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi". About four hours later, Das posted